

Where Attention Fails to Translate into Revenue

Revenue vs Attention Map

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Interactive version here: https://hugoarellano.github.io/index_attention_revenue.html

I. Introduction

Revenue and attention are closely related, but not equivalent. Their divergence reveals how effectively firms convert market visibility into economic value.

Companies differ significantly in this conversion: some capture excess attention relative to their size, while others operate at scale with limited visibility. These patterns reflect underlying differences in business models and competitive positioning.

This analysis focuses on the **opportunity zone**—companies with high attention but relatively low revenue—where demand is evident but monetization remains underdeveloped. By isolating these cases, the framework identifies where value is being underextracted.

II. Methodology

2.1 Data Selection and Industry Scope

I began with the **Forbes Global 2000 dataset** and restricted the sample to industries where **consumer attention plays a central role in revenue generation**, including:

- Media
- Hotels, Restaurants & Leisure
- Retailing
- Household & Personal Products
- Food, Drink & Tobacco
- Consumer Durables

The filtering produced 322 firms; the analysis then focused on the 140 largest by revenue.

2.2 Attention Index Construction

Company names were converted into search items representing the primary consumer-facing brand. For example, *The Walt Disney Company* was mapped to Disney.

For holding groups, the most recognizable consumer brand was selected (e.g., *Inditex* → *Zara*).

Next, search interest data for each search item was collected from Google Trends for the last 12 months.

To construct a comparable index, the queries were processed in 20 batches, using Coca-Cola as the anchor item (*Coca-Cola* = 1).

An index value below 1 indicates that the search item receives less attention than Coca-Cola, while an index value above 1 indicates higher relative attention.

Finally, after collecting the search interest data, several companies exhibited negligible search attention relative to Coca-Cola. These observations were excluded from the analysis, resulting in a final sample of 118 companies.

2.3 The Attention model

To improve visualization and reduce scale distortions, both **revenue** and **attention index** were transformed using the **logarithmic scale**.

This transformation allows companies of very different sizes to be represented more clearly in the chart.

An **expected attention model** was then estimated using a linear regression of the form:

$$\log(\text{Attention}) = a \cdot \log(\text{Revenue}) + b$$

This regression estimates the **expected level of attention** a company should receive given its revenue size.

Next, **Attention Alpha** was calculated as the residual of the model:

$$\text{Attention Alpha} = \log(\text{Attention}) - \log(\text{Expected Attention})$$

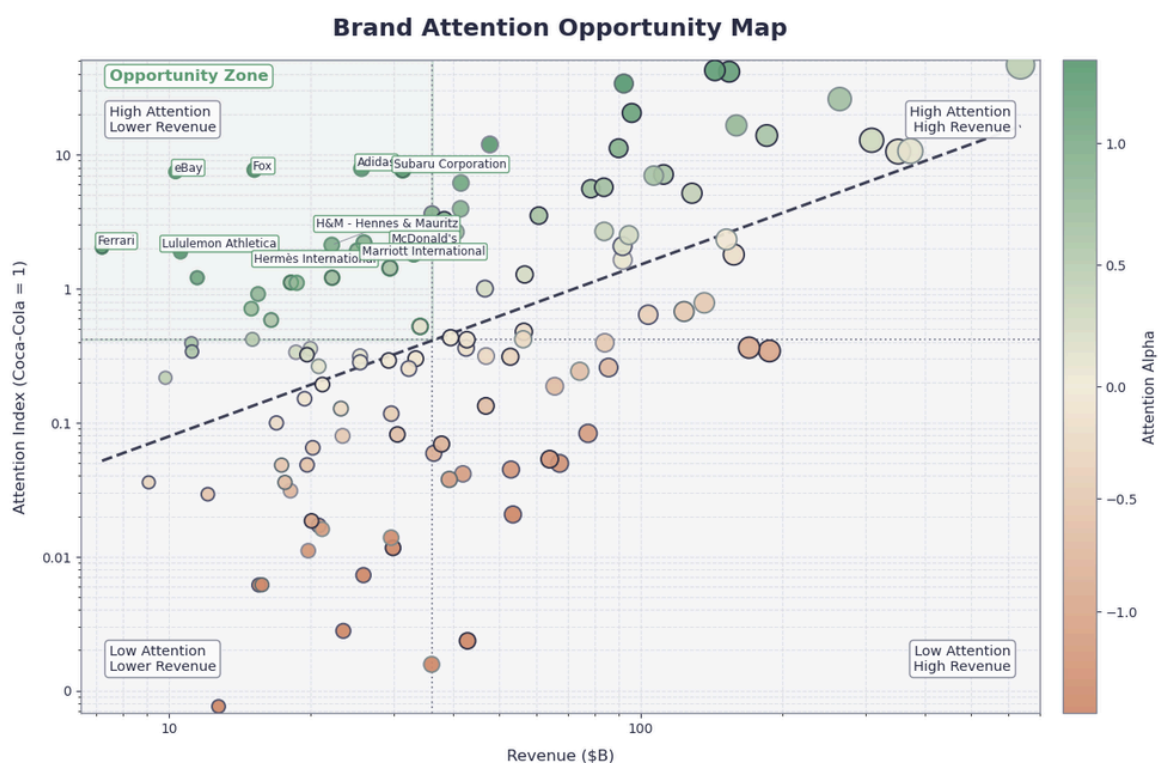
In practice, this corresponds to the difference between observed attention and the level predicted by the regression model.

Positive values indicate that a company receives more attention than expected given its revenue, while negative values indicate less attention than expected.

III. Results

Labeled companies represent the **top positive attention outliers among firms with relatively high absolute attention**.

The **dashed line** shows the **expected level of attention given a company's revenue**, estimated from the regression model. Companies **above the line** receive **more attention than expected**, while those **below the line** receive **less attention than expected**.



The **median lines** divide the chart into four quadrants:

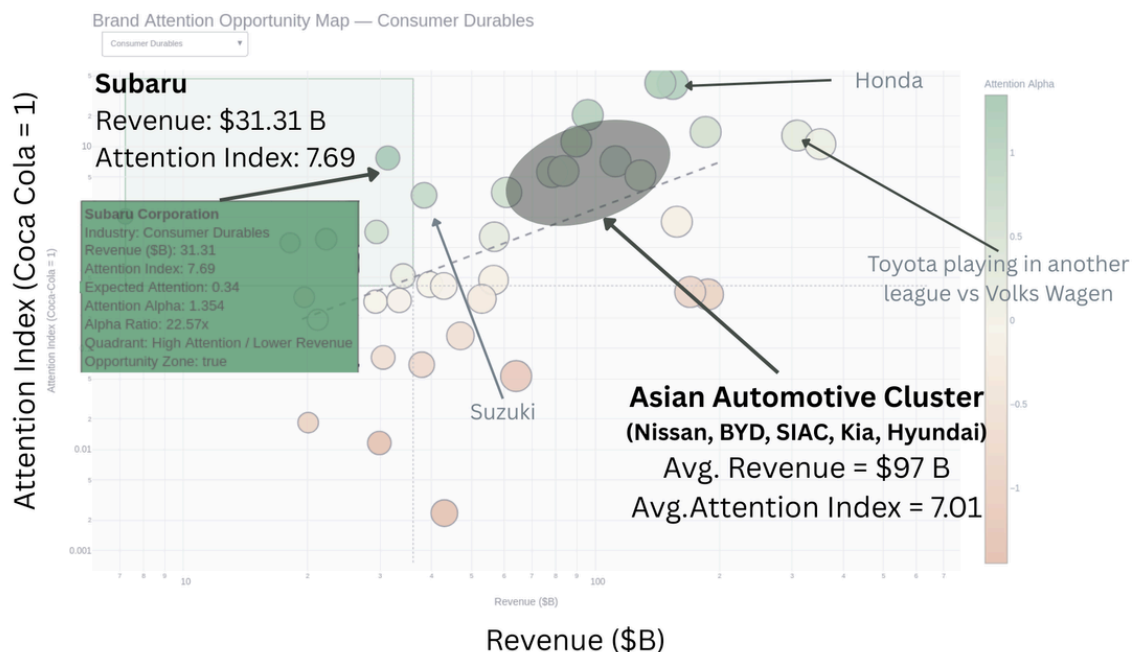
- **High Attention / Low Revenue:** brands with attention that exceeds their current business scale. (*Priority: Improve conversion, pricing, or distribution*).

- **High Attention / High Revenue:** Efficient monetization / attention rate.
- **Low Attention / High Revenue:** Large businesses with relatively weak public attention.
- **Low Attention / Low Revenue:** smaller companies.

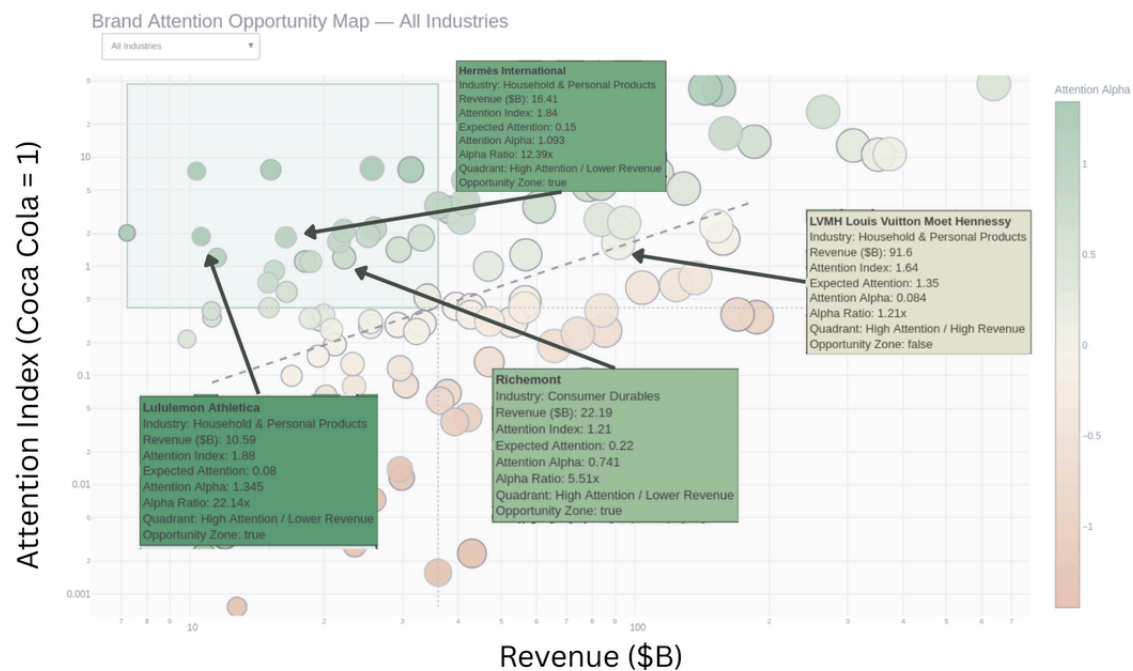
3.1 Global Findings

A. Within the consumer durables category, the most notable pattern emerges in the **automotive sector**. Subaru captures attention levels comparable to larger Asian manufacturers—such as Nissan, Kia, Hyundai, BYD, and SAIC—despite operating at a significantly smaller revenue scale.

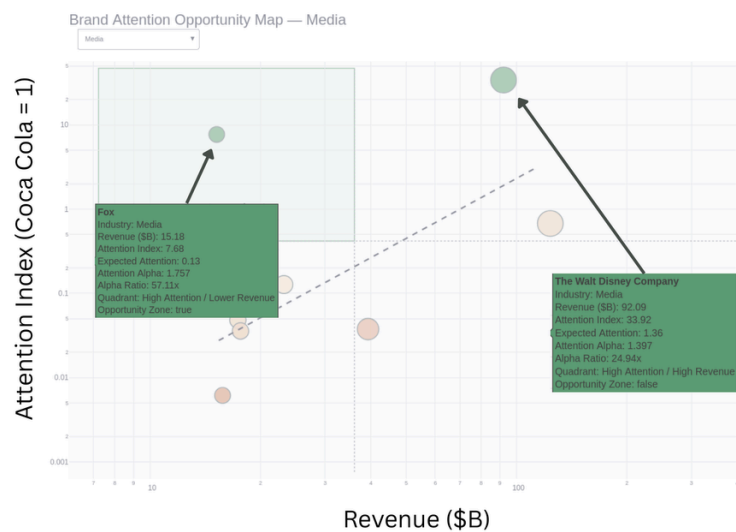
Its brand equity has been built around differentiated engineering choices—most notably the boxer engine and symmetrical AWD—rather than leadership in electrification. **As Subaru entered the EV transition later than its competitors, this suggests that its current attention is driven more by legacy positioning** than by alignment with the industry’s dominant technological shift.



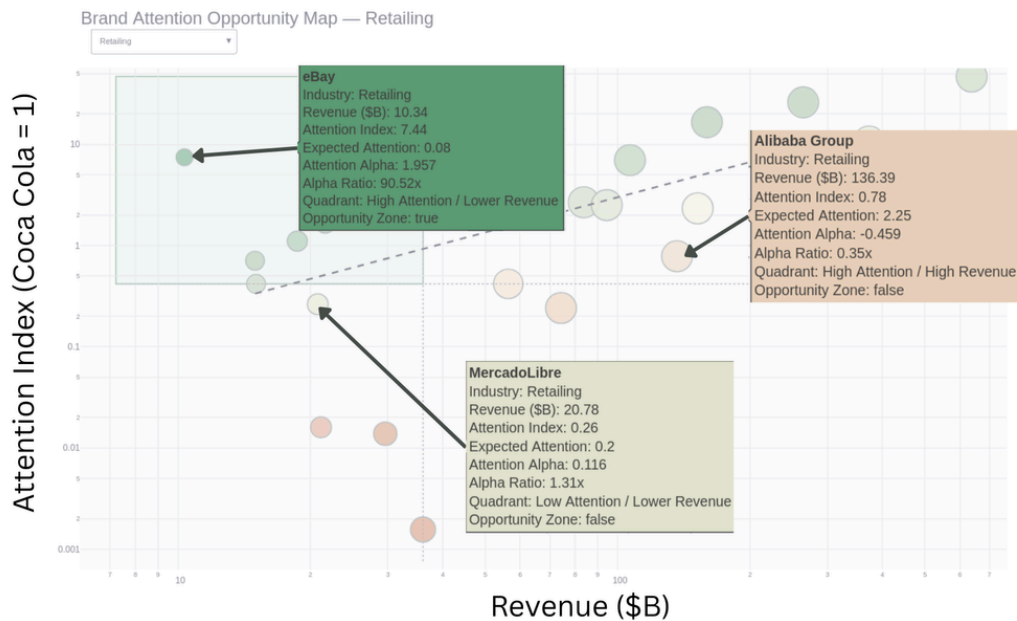
B. Luxury brands often capture disproportionate attention relative to their revenue base, reflecting structural brand power that is not always fully monetized (e.g., Lululemon, Hermès, Ferrari, Richemont). However, some luxury brands successfully convert strong attention into substantial revenue performance, as seen with Louis Vuitton, Mercedes-Benz, and BMW.



C. In the media industry, Disney generates roughly 6× more revenue than Fox, while the attention gap is closer to 4×, suggesting Disney converts brand attention into revenue more efficiently.



D. Across retail platforms, eBay captures roughly 10× more attention than MercadoLibre and Alibaba despite generating substantially less revenue—about half of MercadoLibre’s and only 7% of Alibaba’s.



IV. Limitations

Closed platform ecosystems

A structural limitation of search-based attention metrics is the migration of user activity toward closed digital ecosystems. Companies such as MercadoLibre and Alibaba Group actively promote mobile app adoption, where product discovery and transactions occur within the platform rather than through external search engines. As a result, search-based signals may underrepresent the true scale of user engagement.

Multi-platform ecosystems

Some companies operate multiple digital platforms that distribute user activity across several apps or services. For example, Alibaba’s ecosystem includes Taobao, Tmall, AliExpress, and Alibaba.com. This fragmentation can dilute search signals tied to a single brand or query.

Geographic bias in search behavior

Search behavior varies significantly across regions. While Google holds roughly 90% of the search market in Western economies, Baidu dominates China with approximately 63% market share. Analyses based primarily on Google search signals may therefore underestimate attention in markets where alternative search engines prevail.

Brand vs. product-level attention

This analysis is conducted at the brand/company level, whereas consumers often search for specific products rather than brand itself.

Differences in monetization models

Companies operate under different economic models, which affects how attention converts into revenue. Marketplace platforms, subscription businesses, luxury brands, and inventory-based retailers monetize attention in fundamentally different ways. Consequently, similar levels of attention may translate into very different revenue outcomes across firms.

Industry structural scale differences

Finally because the Opportunity Zone is defined using global median thresholds for revenue and attention, some industries may appear entirely inside or entirely outside the zone when filtered individually. This can occur when a sector structurally operates at a different revenue scale relative to the broader sample. In such cases, the visualization may reflect industry-level structural characteristics—such as lower revenue intensity relative to attention—rather than firm-specific opportunity signals.

V. Conclusions

Despite these limitations, the framework remains useful for identifying structural mismatches between brand visibility and economic scale. By highlighting where attention and revenue diverge, the analysis signals potentially under-monetized brands, unusually efficient business models, and broader competitive asymmetries across industries.

In particular, cases where brand visibility significantly exceeds the current economic scale of the firm suggest a distinctive strategic condition: **the brand has grown larger than the business itself**. Building such brand equity typically requires substantial time and investment, making these situations potentially attractive opportunities for expansion or improved monetization.

Several companies illustrate these dynamics. **eBay** captures substantially more search attention than larger e-commerce platforms such as MercadoLibre and Alibaba Group despite generating far less revenue. In the automotive sector, **Subaru** attracts attention comparable to significantly larger manufacturers. In contrast, luxury brands such as **Louis Vuitton**, within LVMH, demonstrate how strong brand attention can be effectively converted into substantial revenue scale among luxury brands.

These asymmetries suggest that gaps between attention and revenue may

reveal structural opportunities for firms capable of transforming brand visibility into economic value.